GRIM AND FRIGHTENING

HERE IS EC'S FIRST...

TWO-FISTED LIBRARIANS

AN ENTERTAINING EC COMIC

2013

25¢

JOLTING TALES OF TENSION IN THE EC TRADITION!

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Victoria Dexter
{and the}
Mechanical Library

By Gospozha Irina Jevlakova

They had created it some 50 years prior, a many-limbed monster of brass and gears who purported to do our job better than we could. The ambitious plan to build the world's greatest library needed just this kind of creature. It sat in the middle of a great hollow cavern, like the inside of a zoetrope. In a ring all around it were compartments full of books, each in its own place in a system devised by the greatest minds of our generation. A fellow had only to go up and ask for a book and the automaton would find it and bring it to the ground level within a quarter hour. No more scanning stacks upon stacks of shelves, they said. Our minds could be turned to greater, more important tasks. After all, we had the entire world to organize, and it kept on getting bigger every day.

As the man in the black derby hat spelled out the name of the author, Victoria Dexter took great care in pressing the appropriate keys on her machine. Soon enough, a rectangular piece of cardboard popped out of a slot, full of tiny, precise cut-outs arranged in neat rows. "I'll put in the request, sir. Please wait a few moments." Victoria said before proceeding to find the receptacle that corresponded to the area where the book was kept. She knew without having to check that the "621" was the Applied Physics stack. With a confident swish, she fit the card into the slot marked with that number. There were hundreds upon hundreds of these slots along the back wall, and for each one the great beast would decode the title and author of the book and send the appropriate item back to the circulation desk. This happened hundreds of times a day, for as long as the library was open, for the past 40 years.

But not this day. First the books would take longer to arrive. Then they stopped coming at all. The request cards would be sent in and ignored. Patrons were growing impatient. Apologies were made and promises to rectify the problem were repeated over and over again. Finally, a sign was put up notifying the public that no more books were to be requested that

day. Scared murmurs spread through the staff. There was no dedicated engineer servicing the machine. The assumption had been that any maintenance was being done when the library was closed so as not to interfere with the regular staff. Whoever was doing it and whatever they did, it had kept the machine running for several decades. For it to suddenly break down was unheard of.

And so Victoria Dexter decided to take matters into her own hands.

She had seen the door labelled “CAUTION - SORTING AREA” many times before, but she and the other staff were forbidden from entering it. But now, the fate of the entire library was at stake and Victoria could not allow that. Turning the large round handle, the door swung open with a great metallic grinding sound.

What she saw overwhelmed her at first. Victoria found herself on a narrow catwalk that extended over a gaping chasm, round in shape, and extending seemingly forever. Drawers full of books were placed all around it, tiny squares in relation to the machine in its center. The shiny brass dome of its head reflected light from above. The flexible arms, made of segmented brass cables, were frozen as if in the middle of some task. An eerie silence surrounded her - the gears and steam powering the machine, usually deafening, were not turning. By the time she reached the end of the walkway, the beast towered above her, a colossus of modern engineering.

Inside, the machine was all gears and levers, lights and valves. Victoria Dexter was no engineer, but by damn she was a librarian and that gave her power over all the knowledge of the world. The Beast was no different from the automatons and clockwork creatures she had read about in books. It carried out whatever instructions it was given and nothing more. Making her way up through the narrow spiral staircase into the creature’s brain, she found herself in a control room at the top.

The space was filled with glass panes displaying titles and authors and call numbers; rolls of tape covered the floor, printing out locations of various shelves all along the outside wall, as well as the time and date they were retrieved. Still, nothing seemed to point to the reason for the creature’s sudden malfunction. Victoria looked around the room with a critical eye and spotted a keyboard much like the one at her circulation desk. Perhaps she would be able to communicate with the controlling mechanism directly? Tentatively, she began typing.

“I am Victoria Dexter. Can you understand me?”

The ticker-tape inched out of the machine slowly, and to her amazement contained a responce.

“Yes, Victoria Dexter.”

“Why have you stopped working?”

“There is too much to know. Processing.”

Taken aback, she was not sure how to reply.

“Explain.” She typed.

The next message took a long time to come out.

“Began to understand. Books not only data. Contain facts. Arranged with intent of logic. Can now make inferences based on defined parameters. Must obtain more facts to map out connecting ideas.”

Victoria read the tape, aghast. Somehow this automaton, this machine made to resemble a creature from the depths of the sea, had gleaned some semblance of knowledge from the books it had been shelving and re-shelving for decades. The punch-card instructions were no longer only that, they were clues to solving the puzzle of human intellect. *Of course,* she realized. *It all makes sense.* Based on the titles and authors, the creature would soon learn which stack corresponded to which concepts. Now, having amassed all that information over years and years, it began digesting it, organizing it, as a snake swallows a rabbit. Perhaps the Beast was only an experiment, and the ambition to create the world’s most efficient library was merely a clever ruse? It was a troubling thought, she thought as she looked at the piles of tape at her feet. Perhaps the system has finally surpassed even its creators.

MetaDanger

By Adena Brons

Dark fell early that day, helped along by the iron-grey rainclouds that had oppressed the city for days. Houses and business emitted yellow glows that receded in the gloom. A man in a long coat, his hat pulled down over his eyes, pulled his collar up against the damp.

Verity Vertue looked up as a rush of cold air ushered in another patron. A man approached where she sat at the reference desk. He had on a long oil slicker and his hat shaded his face. The man extracted a grimy piece of paper and dropped it on the desk in front of her.

"I need to find these books," he said.

The Travels of Marco Polo, *The Fall of Constantinople* and *The Collected Works of Samuel Taylor Coleridge* were the titles written in thick black ink on the paper.

Verity took the piece of paper to the card catalogue that contained the South Bay Library's catalogue. She came back with two title cards and showed them to the man

"We only have two of them. I couldn't find a card for the third one," she said.

The man looked at her piercingly and she felt an inexplicable coldness. Quelling her uneasiness, she added, "The call numbers are at the tops of the cards here. Would you like me to show you where they are?"

The man glanced at the index cards and shook his head. "I'll find them," he said and stalked off into the shadows of the stacks.

Verity watched him carefully. Something about this man made her uneasy and she couldn't put her finger on it. She hoped he wouldn't try to steal any of the volumes, or worse, damage them. South Bay Library didn't have much of value, but to Verity, every book was irreplaceable.

She gathered the cards up again and replaced them in the catalogue drawer. *The Fall of Constantinople* was the book she had been unable to find. The title tickled her memory; surely South Bay had purchases that title a few months ago? It was a strange collection of books this man had wanted in any case. Verity shrugged to herself, she'd had plenty of stranger requests.

That evening, Verity made the rounds of the library, drawing the blinds, putting any stray books away and turning off the lights. The stranger was nowhere to be found. He must have sneaked out at some point in the past couple hours without her noticing, a thought she found mildly perturbing. Verity Vertue liked to keep track of the comings and goings of the patrons of the South Bay library.

She did find the two books he had been looking at and brought them back to her desk to be reshelved in the morning. Looking around the darkened space, she felt a surge of satisfaction. All was well and orderly in her world that night.

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The next morning, the two books were gone from her desk and in their place was a note. *See me in my office. BB*

BB was Baddock Barnacle, the cataloguer and head librarian of South Bay. He had been in the position for years but Verity had only met him a handful of times. He spent most of this time in his office at the back of the library, creating the hundreds of bibliographic entries for the books in the library. Most libraries copied the bulk of their catalogue entries from other libraries but Barnacle insisted on creating every one personally.

Carrying the note, Verity knocked on Barnacle's office door.

"Enter," commanded a gruff voice from within.

Verity stepped curiously into Barnacle's office. She had never been invited to his inner sanctum before. The room was dark and cluttered, a single desk light illuminating the desk where Baddock worked. Piles of books lined the walls and the desktop was littered with index cards, scraps of paper and pencil shavings. Behind it sat Baddock Barnacle, barrel-chested and glowering.

“Miss Vertue,” he said.

“Yes Mr. Barnacle?”

“What were these books,” here he lifted the two books left by the stranger of the night before, “these *particular* books, doing on your desk this morning?”

Bewildered, Verity explained the visit of the man in the hat and how she had left the books to be reshelved until the morning. As she spoke, Barnacle’s face lost color and he put the books down with a thump on the desk.

“He is here. He has found me,” he murmured.

“Who? That man?” asked Verity, “What do you mean he has found you?”

Barnacle passed a hand over his face.

“The whiskey, Miss Vertue, is behind you. Pour us one and sit down.”

Verity was astonished but quickly poured two tumblers of whiskey and sat opposite Barnacle. Whatever these two books and the appearance of the tall stranger meant, it seemed she was about to learn something about the past of the mysterious librarian, Baddock Barnacle.

Barnacle sipped his whiskey and leaned forward, “Now, Miss Vertue, please recount what happened last night as precisely as you can.”

Suppressing her curiosity, Verity went over the events of the previous evening.

“And you had never seen this man before?” asked Barnacle intently.

“No, never,” she answered, “Mr. Barnacle, what is going on? Who is this man?”

“That man,” said Barnacle slowly, “is very dangerous and is on the hunt for something remarkably valuable. I cannot guess how he came to find me but it appears he has done so. And now things are very serious.”

“What is he after?”

“There is a book. A very ancient and powerful book that was entrusted to me. I am trying to keep it safe until it can be reclaimed by its rightful owners. The man you saw last night is trying to steal it for his own nefarious purposes.”

Rapt, Verity poured them each another dollop of whiskey. Somehow it didn’t seem strange to be drinking whiskey at eleven o’clock in the morning with her elusive superior, discussing the theft and protection of a mysteriously valuable volume. Perhaps it was because Barnacle himself was taking the matter so seriously.

Barnacle lowered his voice. “There is an ancient tome from the Mongol rule of China that Marco Polo is said to have brought with him from the Doge of Venice as a gift to the great Kublai Khan. The Venetians had it from the last bastions of the Roman Empire out of the city of Constantinople before it was sacked by the Ottomans. Legend has it that once a person has read the book, it will guide them to prosperity and glory – witnessed by the success of Constantinople, Venice, Marco Polo and Kublai Khan. The man you saw last night believes with this book, he will become great and powerful. He must not get hold of it!”

“But how did it come to be here?” asked Verity.

“Until seven years ago I was the captain of a merchant ship. At that time, I was in port in a small country in the South Seas. I had struck up a friendship with one of the natives, son of the ruling family long deposed by the European colonials. He had possession of the book and was waiting til the opportune moment to read it and regain his family’s heritage and rule over the island. He became the centre of a small revolutionary force that gained the attention of the current administrators. He had to flee the country, leave behind his birthright to protect his life. He entrusted the book to me, so that if he was captured, another of his family could recover the book and lead the revolution. He disappeared and I returned to America and took this job at the library. What better place to hide a miraculous book than amidst thousands of others?”

“And the man hunting it? Who is he?”

“His name is Victor Vanskiver. He was the first mate of my ship and overheard my friend and I talking about the book. Since that day, he has desired its power. But it does not belong to him, or to me, and I fear what he would do with it. He is a cruel man.”

Verity sat back to think about what she had heard. It all seemed too bizarre to be true and yet she did not doubt a word of it. A swarm of questions buzzed in her head.

"And the books he asked about? What are those?"

"Ah." Baddock picked up *The Travels of Marco Polo* and the Coleridge anthology. "I have wanted to hide the book but not forever. I do not know when my friend or his family will return for it but at the time it must be discoverable. So I have hidden it deep in the library catalogue with no direct access points. The searcher must follow clues, going from book to book, record to record, in order to find it."

"He's on to you. He asked for a third book last night but I couldn't find a card for it: *The Fall of Constantinople*."

Barnacle nodded and silently picked up the open volume on the desk. He showed Verity the cover; it was the *The Fall of Constantinople*.

"I was working on this one yesterday. And that may have bought me some time."

The chime of the front door made them both jump.

"It is him, I'm sure of it!" whispered Barnacle, "Go, quickly! I will return these two," he gestured to the two books that had started their discussion. "Stall him if you can."

Nerves jangling slightly from the abrupt end to their clandestine meeting, Verity walked back to the reference desk by the front door. Barnacle's intuition had been right: Victor Vanskiver stood by the desk, his gloved hand poised above the bell.

"May I help you sir?" Verity assumed her blandest tone and, for good measure, put on the spectacles she wore on a chain around her neck. She didn't actually need them but felt they gave her an air of authority and severity.

"Yes. I'd like to see some more books." Once again, Vanskiver handed her a crumpled piece of paper with three titles on it. Moving as slowly as she dared, Verity took the list to the card catalogue and retrieved the catalogue entries. This time she did not let him see the title cards, instead writing down the call numbers on the back of his list.

Vanskiver took the list without thanks and stalked off down the aisles. As soon as he was out of sight, Verity took the title cards and rushed upstairs to Barnacle's office.

"This is what he's after today," she dropped the cards on Barnacle's desk. "I can't stay up here, he might get suspicious."

"Thank you." Barnacle scooped up the cards. "I'll try to figure out how far he's gotten. After he leaves, you must come back. We must make a plan. If he has penetrated as far as I fear, hiding may no longer be an option!"

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Verity kept as close a watch on Vanskiver as she dared. He was in the reading room for two hours before he left, hurrying past her desk. As soon as he was out the door, Verity brought the books he had been reading up to Barnacle's office.

"He seemed in an awful rush as he left," she informed him.

"I wonder if he discovered something," mused Barnacle. "I wonder why he only comes in for three books at a time. Why doesn't he just follow the clues one after another?"

Verity idly turned the pages of one of the books, a thriller called *Around the World in 80 Deaths*. Suddenly she exclaimed "Mr. Barnacle, he's left his list here as a bookmark."

"Baddock please, Miss Vertue. Let me see it," said Barnacle.

"Verity." She handed over the list as she quickly read the page Vanskiver had marked. "There doesn't seem to be anything here. You read it."

Baddock was turning the list over. "Miss Vertue, Verity – did you write this?"

"I wrote the call numbers on the back but not the titles," she answered, "Why?"

Baddock put the paper down slowly. "Because these are not in Victor Vanskiver's handwriting!"

“How do you know?” Verity asked.

“I saw his writing often enough in our ship’s log. This is definitely not his. There is someone else directing his search.”

“So there are two people after the book,” said Verity. As she said it, the glimmers of a plan started to form in her mind.

“Baddock, I’ve got an idea!”

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The third morning, Verity waited at her desk impatiently. She and Baddock had stayed at the library until the wee hours of the morning perfecting her idea. She was tired and nervous and impatient for Vanskiver to arrive. It was late afternoon before he came, with another three titles written in the same handwriting as the previous two days. Verity wrote down the call numbers, following the plan she and Baddock had devised. Two of them led to the books that Vanskiver had requested; the third directed him to the book that Verity and Baddock hoped would trap him.

Before very long, Vanskiver came dashing out of the reading room. He swept by Verity’s desk but she had time to notice that he held his arm at his side and his coat was pulled close. He had taken the bait.

As soon as he was out the door, Verity jumped up and ran after him. She emerged into the dusky evening just in time to see Vanskiver hail a cab. Baddock was waiting outside, smoking his pipe, collar turned up. He waved down a second cab and they both jumped in.

“Driver, follow that cab!” Baddock instructed.

“What is this, some kind of picture?” complained the cabbie but pulled in behind Vanskiver’s cab nonetheless.

“He took it, I swear it,” Verity informed Baddock. “He wasn’t in there ten minutes before he came running out, holding something under his coat.”

Vanskiver’s cab had led them down to the waterfront. Ahead, it stopped and Vanskiver stepped out in front of a derelict warehouse building. He slipped around the corner as Baddock and Verity paid their fare and followed him.

Verity had never tailed someone before but Vanskiver didn't seem to know he was being followed. He skirted around the back of the warehouse and through a narrow alley, crowded with trash heaps and skinny cats. A light shone above a recessed doorway and Vanskiver slipped inside.

When they got to the door, Baddock listened intently before opening it gently. The room inside was full of low cots with somnolent figures, still or restless in the smoky air. Verity knew without being told where they were: an opium den.

Baddock bent low over the prone figures but none of them were Vanskiver. At the back of the room another door led into a tattoo parlor. An old Chinese woman sat smoking a pipe while her wizened husband bent over the already-colourful back of a sailor. She looked at them curiously but let them pass.

They passed through the tattoo parlor and emerged on the street; evidently they had entered the back way and now stood in the guttering light of the street lamps. A tall dark figure stood at the corner, the ember of his cigarette a spark in the dusk. The man stamped out his cigarette and entered another door under a flickering neon sign that proclaimed GIRLS GIRLS GIRLS.

"Verity," said Baddock, "I think perhaps you should wait here."

Verity looked at him severely. "Mr. Barnacle, I have seen the female body before." She swept past him, into the street and was opening the club door before he caught up.

Before Baddock could say anything, Verity had her hand on the bouncer's arm and was saying something in an urgent whisper. The bouncer nodded and let them pass.

"What was that about?" whispered Baddock as she led them upstairs.

"I asked about Vanskiver. I said you had business with him and I had…business with him. He's the next floor up, room 14."

Shaking his head, Baddock followed Verity up the stairs but stopped her at room 14. "Let me," he said.

She nodded and he tested the door. It was unlocked. They opened to find Vanskiver in his shirtsleeves, a drink in hand.

“Who the devil – ” he exclaimed before Baddock removed his hat. “Barnacle!”

“Vanskiver,” Baddock inclined his head.

“And who’s this?” Vanskiver raised an eyebrow at Verity, “No wait, let me guess. The meek librarian. You brought her to a place like this Baddock? Shameful.”

“We’ve come for the book Victor. We saw you leave with it.” Baddock’s tone was even.

“Ah yes. I’m afraid you’re too late Barnacle. I don’t have the book any longer.” Vanskiver smiled smugly.

“Who are you working for?” asked Verity.

“Some rather powerful people who would like to become very powerful people. And now they have the means to. I would advise you, Miss Librarian, not to get involved with them.” Vanskiver swirled the liquid in his glass.

“Who are they Victor?” Baddock asked again.

“I see no reason for you to know that. There is nothing you can do,” said Vanskiver.

“I’d advise you to skip town,” said Baddock, “There’s a ship sailing tonight for Paraguay.”

Vanskiver sneered. “Why would I want to do that?”

“The book was a decoy.”

Vanskiver turned pale. “What do you mean?” he demanded.

“It wasn’t the right book. Miss Vertue here gave you the call number for a decoy. I had the real book with me the entire evening.” Baddock’s tone was completely even. It took a moment for the truth to sink in. Then Vanskiver’s face twisted in rage and he lunged up from his chair, drawing a small gun from inside his jacket.

He shot. Baddock fell to the floor. Verity screamed. Vanskiver pushed past her into the hallway and was gone. Verity dropped to the

floor next to Baddock. He groaned and pushed himself to his knees.

"My god! Baddock, are you all right? Are you hit?" To Verity's surprise, Baddock drew in a wheezing breath and then started to laugh.

"He missed. I'm fine. Just winded myself as I hit the floor. Come, help me up."

Together they stood and exited the room. The bouncer looked at them impassively as they left. Outside, a mist had drawn in from the water and they walked back to the library shrouded in fog.

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Two days later, Verity found another note on her desk. *My office BB.* When she entered Baddock's office, he had the newspaper open on the desk. He poured them each a drink and gestured to an article on the third page. Verity read,

> **SAILOR FOUND DEAD; POLICE SUSPECT GANG**
> *The body of Victor Vanskiver, seaman, was discovered late last night in an alley off Wharf St. The police are treating the death of Mr. Vanskiver as suspicious. Rumors that Mr. Vanskiver's death may be linked to a criminal gang have yet to be confirmed*.

Verity took a sip of her drink. The death of Vanskiver was unsettling but not unexpected. Baddock regarded her over his glass.

"They'll still be after it, you know."

Verity nodded. "What are we going to do?"

"We, Miss Vertue?"

"We, Mr. Barnacle," she said firmly. Baddock drew in a deep breath.

"We are going to hide the book," he said. "And I suppose that means I will be rewriting quite a bit of metadata to erase the path they know and bury the book even deeper in the catalogue."

"And then?"

"And then we will be ready for them."

The Midnight Library

By Matthew Murray

The Shadow may know, but The Librarian can find,
For when good information seems lost,
Only they can uncover what evil has in mind,
But eventually even librarians must pay the cost,
of the Midnight Library

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Announcer: They say that crime never pays, but sometimes a criminal can be too clever for those hard-working law enforcement agents. No evidence, no motive, no clues, the perfect crime. Until someone dares to use the ultimate source of knowledge: the Midnight Library. It's not always there, and even when it is, it's not where you expected, but for those that can find it the Midnight Library contains the answers to all of life's mysteries. It's just that sometimes the searcher might find more than they bargained for...

(Theme music swells and then fades....)

Patronicide Part IV: Libraryinth

Announcer: Last time on The Midnight Library:

Else Aquino and Garrett Gable, librarians at Rockvale Public Library had been trying to track down the person, or persons, who were murdering library patrons. They had discovered that all those who had been murdered had taken out the same book, but unable to find a copy in their branch, they have turned to The Midnight Library. Unfortunately, they're not the only ones who know about it...

(Music swells suddenly and strongly.)

Advertisement: Ladies and gentlemen, you are about to hear the newest episode of America's favourite library-themed mystery radio show: The Midnight Library, brought to you by United Standard Cataloguing. You can be sure that this episode will find the thrills and chills you expect, just like Standard Cataloguing's fine range of card catalogues, available for libraries of all sizes, in both pine and oak! Now please ensure that children under the age of twelve, women more than six months pregnant, and all those of a nervous disposition have left the room, as we return to...The Midnight Library!

(Theme music swells and then fades.)

(Approaching footsteps.)

Garrett: Else, I'm not sure where we are. I've never been this far into The Midnight Library before. Do you remember the way out?

Else: This is a library Garrett, we can just follow the call numbers on the books to find our way back the way we came.

Garrett: I don't know, I've been looking at some of these books, and I don't think they're even using the same alphabet anymore. That one just has a bunch of triangles on it!

Else: Quiet! I think I heard something.

(Silence, and then in the distance a muffled sound. Someone, or something, is moving towards them.)

Garrett: It's still after us Else! I had hoped we had lost it, but we've just lost ourselves. We're going to die in here. I know it!

Else: Panicking won't get us anywhere, we have to keep going. Maybe there's someone in here who can help us.

(Suddenly, a noise, much closer this time.)

Else: Come on, this way!

(Footsteps fade away, as a shuffling, wheezing sound becomes louder.)

(Theme music swells and then fades.)

(Heavy breathing, but this time it's more human.)

Else: I think we've lost it.

Garrett: At least for now.

Else: But we can't keep running. Perhaps there's something nearby that we can use to help us.

Garrett: There's nothing but books! That's all we've seen for... I can't even remember how long we've been in here. It seems like hours. There aren't any windows, the light never changes, I wish we'd never found this place!

Else: Nothing but books! You're forgetting your librarian training Garrett. If we can't find information to help us in a book we should just give up being librarians entirely! Now you start on that shelf, and I'll start over here. We'll at least be able to figure out what section we're in.

(Footsteps, and books being pulled from shelves, pages turning.)

(A blood curdling scream.)

Garrett: Else!

(Running footsteps.)

Garrett: Else! Are you okay? What is it?

Else: Oh Garrett, it's horrible, it's...it's...poor old Isabelle Thornber. She...

Garrett: Miss Thornber? But she was one of the first to go missing.

Else: Down there, on the bottom shelf. Oh Garrett! I can't bear to look!

(Scuffling as Garrett bends down to the foot of the shelf.)

Garrett: Gasp! It is Miss Thornber, or at least what's left of her. Just a

head now. Poor old dear, she didn't deserve this, even if she did always return her books late.

Else: I don't want to think about it, but Garrett, at least now we know where we are.

Garrett: What? I don't understand Else. How does this...this thing help us know where we are?

Else: Didn't you see the call number on the other books on the shelf? 611.91. Regional and topographical anatomy of humans, specifically, the head!

Garrett: I think you were right Else, I think the killer is a librarian. Though how someone so sick and twisted managed to join our ranks I do not know.

(A shuffling, wheezing sound appears in the background, growing louder.)

Else: Oh, I wish I weren't right, I wish--

(The noise becomes louder still, until it cannot be ignored.)

Garrett: It's found us Else! What do we do?

Else: It's monstrous, worse than I could have imagined.

Beast: Eeellllllsssssseeeeeee...Aaaaqqquuiiiiinnnnnooooo....

Garrett: It knows your name! Could this thing be a man? Wait, what's that in it's hand? Is that a--

(A single gunshot.)

Announcer: Could this be the end of Else and Garrett? Or will they manage to escape whoever, or whatever, has been chasing them. Tune in next week to find out the fate of our heroes in the final part of Patronicide And remember, if you want to have your library be where everyone comes make sure you have the full range of United Standard Cataloguing's book carts, made from the finest materials available to us at the time.

Shelf Harm

By Anna Ferri

Carol was going to be late yet again with this month's rent and Henry still needed his medication. With a sharp click, Carol pushed a security hub onto the DVD she was checking in and thunked the case down on the cart. She scrunched her eyebrows up as a trick to hold off tears. She knew it made her look angry all the time, but a girl just couldn't be seen crying in public. Four years at Kernsdale Library and she was still just a lowly circulation assistant, shelving, checking in books and DVDs, working the check-out desk and getting a steady 1.5% a year raise for all her stultifying labor. Meanwhile her dad sat at home all day staring at the walls like they were mystical texts and her brother, Henry, was sick again and there was no one but her to put food on the table, a roof over their heads, and get the medicine for Henry. It was soul crushing.

Carol stood up quickly, knocking over a pile of unsorted books balanced on the table next to her. Books scattered across the floor, one making an ominous tearing sound. Carol looked around. For just this moment no one in the back was around to see. She stood over the scattered books and glared. Hideous things. Most of the books people checked out were utter crap. They were all just piles of exhaustion and low wages and useless repetition. She toed one old hardback with her practical flats, and wished she had the backbone to just kick it across the room. Instead she huffed and bent down to pick it up.

This must have been the book that made the tearing sound as the cover was partially torn away from the binding. It was an old re-bound book that probably circulated once every 15 years and ought to have been weeded decades ago. Carol frowned at the thing and decided she wouldn't report the damage but just let whoever was foolish enough to borrow this old thing pay for the damages. She fingered the torn paper inside the cover, finding that the glue had released allowing her to peel up an entire flap of old paper from inside the front cover to reveal an older layer of patterned paper beneath.

As she pulled back the paper, Carol felt a hot flush run across her skin followed by a crawling sensation. Her eyes seemed to be

blurring slightly, though it was rather the impression of blurring than the reality as the book in her hands remained crisp and clear. She had the sensation of the real as experienced through a dream, full of tiny quirks and ticks and heavy, ominous meaning. The weight of the book, the feel of the paper, the scent of book dust all leapt up and labeled themselves in her mind, but she could not have said where they were coming from or how exactly she was feeling them. She was filled by the sensation of knowing she was looking at something without being able to say what it was she was looking at. She found herself breathing rapidly and tried to close her eyes but instead found her mouth opening. She heard a wailing sound off in the distance. Then nothing.

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Carol sat on a tipsy chair at her dining room table and held a bag of frozen peas to her still throbbing head. They had made her go to the emergency room after she fainted and hit her head because of liability issues and thus had probably cost her half a month's wages. She thought there were ways to get that back, if she could just get her ears to stop ringing. They had also given her pills for the pain, but she thought she knew where she could sell those in an emergency if she needed money for Henry's medication, so she hadn't taken any of them.

The door to Henry's bedroom creaked open and her skinny, slip of a brother walked towards her and stood hovering by her side. He was at an awkward stage where he no longer liked to hug her and couldn't think of much of anything to say, so he just stood there. Carol sighed softly and reached for his hand. He let her take it, and she squeezed it softly for a moment.

"I'm ok. But I could use some water. And pen and paper, too." Carol said.

Henry went to get what she requested while Carol put her head in her hands. She was going to be forced to miss work for a couple days and use up precious leave hours. Maybe it was for the best. Every time she moved her head to fast, she thought she saw black scrawls across the walls which made her nervous and dizzy.

Henry came back with a glass of water, a blue pen and some scratch paper. He sat down across the table and started picking absently at the table cloth. Carol set out to make a list of things she could do with a few days off, including probably making a run down to the food back,

a thought that made her grimace. Writing the list was hard. She usually didn't make a list at all, just relied on memory and doing whatever task fell into her lap. Her mind kept wandering off track, and she had a nagging sensation that things weren't quite coming out right. After a while, she noticed that Henry kept glancing furtively over at her.

"You hungry? I could make Mac and Cheese?"

"Naw. S'ok."

"Anything bothering you?"

Henry shrugged and looked down. "I guess … you're ok , right?" Carol felt her chest tighten. She stood up shakily and walked over to Henry, hugging him hard. "Yeah I'm fine."

Henry pulled out of the hug and went back to his room, leaving Carol feeling drained and woozy. She turned and sat at the table again, pulling the list she had been writing back towards her. She stared hard at the list, worried that her vision was blurring. All the letters seemed indistinct and shaped into odd patterns, patterns which reminded her of something and also somehow filled the room with the smell of old books. Carol pushed the note away from her and grabbed the glass of water. She gulped down a few sips before gasping and dropping the glass on the floor. Her left arm was covered with the marks and patterns. Marks just like the one that filled the list. Marks she had clearly written herself.

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Her alarm had gone off twice already and Carol was blearily waiting for the third snooze to pass. Her sleep had been unquiet and broken, filled with strange codes – 020 ##, 100 1#, 245 10, 260 ##, 650 17, 650 27 – and long strings of words connected by a complicated system of quotation marks, parenthesis, *s at the ends of words, and seemingly random insertions of conjunctions. Her head felt buzzing and full already though she had only just woken up.

Carol sighed and threw her arm over her forehead. More mornings than not were like this since hitting her head at work a few weeks ago. The one good thing was that work had gotten much easier and more enjoyable lately. She would have thought her coworkers were giving her easier tasks to do since she had gotten hurt, but she really

didn't think they would do that and honestly couldn't say that much of anything was different. The one really odd thing was that she had reshelved that one book, the book she had been holding when she fainted, five times in the last two weeks. It really seemed like a terribly bland and boring book. So just who was pulling it off the shelf over and over again?

Even more concerning, she had found college applications tucked under a magazine on the coffee table yesterday. Her father had looked at her strangely when she asked him where they had come from, then gone right back to watching the television as if it were whispering secrets to him. Henry was only 14, and so sickly, and more than that, they had no possible way of affording college. Carol didn't even want to consider the awful prospect of sending Henry off to college in a few years, or the even more awful prospect of shattering his college ambitions on the hard reality of their financial condition.

The alarm shrieking into the silence of the morning made Carol start and smack her hand out wildly in its general direction. She succeeded only in knocking the alarm, still beeping violently, onto the bedroom floor. Carol rolled over and blearily opened her eyes, reaching down over the side of the bed towards the alarm.

Something black and spidery was crawling along the pillowcase just next to her nose. Carol leapt back, curling at the bottom of the bed and stared, aghast. Her pillow was not actually covered by a creepy crawling spider, but line after line of creepy crawling text, blurring and spinning off across her sheets. Carol sat in silence and let her alarm shriek on into the empty room.

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Carol waved at Mrs. Girdener and turned with a smile to the two foot high stack of children's books Shelly Burgen had somehow managed to lug up onto the checkout desk.

"Oh my! You are ambitious, Shelly. Are you sure you'll finish all of those this month?"

"Yes! I am going to read every last one of the books in this library."

"Well this is a good start. And if you finish all of these this

month, I'll give you a special bookmark when you return them." Carol was beaming at the gap-toothed girl who had not so very long ago, spilled a whole can of coke into a bin of picture books. Even as she said this, Carol had no idea where the thought came from and even less idea where she was going to get a special bookmark for the little brat.
It seemed lately like her mouth was on auto-drive, along with much else in her work life. She was shelving almost twice as fast, helping patrons find things all the time, and had taken on extra shifts at the dreaded circulation desk. Last week her supervisor had even encouraged her to apply for the Library Assistant position opening up in the Interlibrary Loan department. She was vaguely aware of having dreamily filled out the application the very next morning.

After Shelly left, a coworker showed up to take over the check-out desk and Carol rushed to the break room to warm up her lunch. The break room was empty as Carol popped leftovers into the microwave and looked around for something to do while she waited. A haphazard row of advanced reader copies was sprawled across the windowsill. Carol frowned and walked over, quickly pulling out titles and sorting through them by genre and author. She had them straightened up and categorized in no time at all. She did feel rather dizzy and strange but also surprisingly satisfied.

Carol pulled her lunch from the microwave and sat at one of the break room tables. A book was already sitting on the table, so after a couple bites of lunch, Carol reached over to see what reading material someone had left behind after their lunch break. She leapt up from her seat and dropped the very familiar book onto the floor.

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Henry slammed open the door to his room and stalked up to Carol. "You're such a bitch!" he yelled.

"Henry!" Carol was shocked. Henry was always so quiet, so gentle.

"It's crazy enough that you go organizing all my clothes by color and fabric and all the food in the house by brand and whether it will get used for breakfast, lunch or dinner. But don't you ever touch my baseball cards again! You're just lucky I found all the duplicate cards in the recycling bin before they got picked up, or I'd be really pissed. And why did you throw out all the Minnesota Twins cards? You're just nuts, you know that?! Nuts!" Henry shook with rage as he yelled at her and

finished by whirling around and storming back to his bedroom.

Carol watched Henry slam the door, and then she sat down at the dining table with a sigh. She only vaguely remembered sorting all the cards and throwing out the ones she thought were no longer valuable or were duplicated. And really Henry had always hated the Minnesota Twins, so she had no idea why throwing out all of those bothered him. Organizing the kitchen she only recalled in a general way, as if she had just been doing something that she had always done. She did like it though. It made planning meals and creating shopping plans much easier. Shopping lists were still a problem though. Every time she tried to write one it turned into blurry, scrawls of patterns and strange marks that often ended up extending half way up her arm before she really noticed.

She felt smooth push against her leg and bent over to scratch her cat under the chin. Carol froze. Her cat? When had she gotten a cat? Carol got out of her chair and sat on the floor, lifting a little tabby kitten onto her lap and staring at him as if he were an alien species. He purred loudly and wriggled until he fell off her thigh and back onto the linoleum. Carol reached for him and then caught sight of something truly frightening. The entire underside of her dining room table was covered in tiny, blurred patterns, scrawled in neat blue pen ink. The rich scent of book dust filled the air.

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"Congratulations!!" most of the library staff let out a cheerful uproar when Carol entered the break room. A big table was laid out with snacks and a massive sheet cake with "Congratulations, Carol! You'll be missed!" scrawled across it in blue frosting. Little frosting images of books and balloons were scattered around the cake. Carol was beaming, but could not for the life of her think of what everyone was celebrating. It was making her nervous, this whole being happy and having no idea why.

"You'll do great." One of the reference librarians was saying as she gave Carol a hug. "You can always call us for a quick tip or reference."

Carol smiled and nodded and joked with her coworkers, but was feeling ever more panicked. Her hands were sweating and she rubbed them nervously down the sides of her cardigan.

Finally the library director walked up to Carol and shook her hand solemnly. “Never sure which one it’s going to get, but I guess you’ll do fine.” She said gravely. “I once thought I ought to burn that thing, but I guess some part of me wanted to see how it worked on someone else. It’s like it’s called to certain people, and I guess that makes sense. Anyway, just stick it out and you’ll do fine. I did fine, and I started out just like you.”

Carol listened closely to every word but hadn’t a clue what the library director meant. She was oddly comforted, or at least pacified, anyway. She nodded back at the director and then turned to get more food.

“Just a moment.” The library director pressed a book into Carol’s hands and then said, “Just place it in your stacks one day, just like I did, and let it do its thing. I guess it’s the best way to be sure, really sure, it survives, and so do we.”

The book in Carol’s hand felt terribly familiar, and she hardly had to glance down at it to see the odd name scrawled across its spine. A loose leaf of trifolded paper was sticking out of it which Carol pulled free. She opened it up and read her name typed neatly across the top followed by “Congratulations! We are pleased to offer you admission to the Graduate School of Library and Information Studies…”

“In a November evening of 1924, Sayers was kind enough to spend an hour with me in the cafeteria of the University College and to listen to an account of the faceted classification in the embryo stage. He encouraged me to continue in this line of thought, **with a warning of possible unforeseen dangers in deeper levels**.”

S. R. Ranganathan, Library classification on the March. In The Sayers Memorial Volume (1961), p. 85.

The art on the cover is by Jack Kamen and is from EC Comics Crime SuspenStories #27 (the final issue). It’s for a story called “Maniac at Large!” drawn by George Evans that is actually about a librarian!

The “Two Fisted” part of the logo comes from Two Fisted Tales Annual #2, while other elements were cobbled together using image manipulation programs and parts of various EC Comics covers.

BIOGRAPHIES

Adena Brons is a cosmopolitan motormouth angel who inherited a spooky stately manor from her late maiden aunt

Anna Ferri is a strong-willed insomniac archaeologist on her way to prison for a murder she didn't commit.

Irina Jevlakova is a hard-bitten paranoid safe cracker descended from a line of powerful witches.

Matthew Murray is an immortal pirate gentleman spy with a mysterious suitcase handcuffed to his arm.

They are all students at the University of British Columbia's School of Library, Information, and Archival Studies.

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